for the use of the garrison. ‘We all slept at our posts,’ wrote Seaton. ‘The officers merely unbuckled their swords, and perhaps changed their boots. None of us wore any uniform – these were carefully put away; but we wore clothes made of camel-hair cloth. The digging, felling, moisture, dust and mud could not hurt them and dirt did not show . . . It was not long before Akbar seemed to be awakening to the fact that his only chance of success was to starve us out.’[44]

It was therefore a major blow to the siege when, on 1 April, the defenders augmented their food supplies by successfully stealing those of their besiegers. Towards the end of March, Akbar Khan had decided to try to deprive the garrison of what little fodder remained by driving his flocks of sheep, under cavalry escort, over the meadows of the foraging grounds in an attempt to remove all remaining grass. With the siege daily tightening its grip, the shepherds grew so confident that, on 31 March, they brought their flocks to within 400 yards of the crest of the glacis. At sunset, the hungry defenders were forced ‘to watch these perambulating chops and legs of mutton vanish in the distance’. But the following day, Sale was ready for them.

The cavalry had been ordered to mount at dawn, and were silently waiting along with 650 infantry, some volunteer pikemen and a diversionary force of Broadfoot’s sappers. As soon as the sheep came within range, the sappers were sent out by the north gate and began firing at the enemy breastworks to draw the attention of the besiegers. Meanwhile, the south gate was quietly thrown open and the cavalry dashed out. The Afghan shepherds and their escort both fled, and the troopers quickly rounded up the sheep and drove them into the city over the drawbridge. The entire manoeuvre took no more than ten minutes. By the time the Afghan cavalry had appeared both sheep and soldiers were safely back within the walls. ‘We were all in the highest spirits,’ wrote Seaton in his diary that night after a celebratory dinner of roast lamb. ‘When the enemy danced with rage, they were saluted with shouts of laughter and “Baa-Baa!” from along the walls. We took four hundred and eighty one sheep and a few goats, which gave sixteen days’ meat for the garrison, at three-quarters ration . . . On the 3rd a spy came in and told us that when Akbar learned that we had captured his sheep, he burst into such a transport of fury, that his people were afraid to go near him.’[45]